Ascendants

Gods, machines, and the desperate: three answers to the same question no one meant to ask.

Table of Contents

Chapter 1: Five Lights Over a Dying House **3**

Act 1: The Weight at the Window *3*

Act 2: The Cheapest Thing He Owned *4*

Act 3: Five Lights, Two Extinguished *6*

Act 4: The Last One to Land *7*

Chapter 2: What the Evolved Could Not Forgive Themselves For **10**

Act 1: The Grief With No Name *10*

Act 2: What Perc Dail Built *11*

Act 3: The Vein Beneath Merrow *11*

Act 4: Six Answers, and a Seventh Question *13*

Chapter 3: The Second Time the Sky Opened **15**

Act 1: The Fall of Corvessa Thane *15*

Act 2: Two Vessels, One Silence *15*

Act 3: Cargo From Another Sky *16*

Act 4: Two Branches From One Root *17*

Act 5: A War With No Winners *18*

Act 6: The Second Kindness *18*

Act 7: The Seam That Never Healed *19*

Chapter 4: The Girl Who Learned What Worship Was For **21**

Act 1: The Third Man on the Altar *21*

Act 2: The Child Who Wasn't Afraid *21*

Act 3: A Girl Who Liked Being Useful *22*

Act 4: The Answer That Came From Belief *23*

Act 5: What Sarei Voss Became *23*

Act 6: A Bridge With No Far Side *24*

Chapter 5: The Story He Did Not Know Was His **26**

Act 1: The Fool King's Story *26*

Act 2: The Hands That Reached In Too Far *26*

Act 3: What He Burned Rather Than Read *27*

Act 4: Every Version That Was True *28*

Act 5: A Name He Never Chose *29*

Act 6: The Fire Still Waiting *29*

Chapter 1

Five Lights Over a Dying House

Act 1: The Weight at the Window

The crowd came at night, because daylight would have made them look at each other's faces, and none of them wanted to see what was there.

They filled the street below the window in a shape that had no edges, not a line, not a circle, just a pressure. Someone had brought a torch, more habit than necessity, since the streetlamps still burned. Someone else had brought a child, who would remember this night for the rest of her life without ever fully understanding it. A man near the front had lost a son in the war at Corvi's Reach. A woman beside him had lost a house, and then a husband, in the resettlement that followed. They did not know each other. They would not have chosen to stand together. But grief has its own gravity, and it had pulled them all to this one door.

Inside, a man stood at the window and looked down at them, and did not move.

He had been called many names across many centuries, traveler, scholar, king, one bureaucratic title after another shed like a coat gone out of fashion, but for the last thirty years he had answered to Grin, and it was Grin's name they were chanting now, twisted into something closer to a curse.

Weak. Coward. Madman.

He had heard worse. He had said worse, once, about other men who had failed at smaller things.

Below him, the crowd did not know it was shouting at the being who had made the stars they navigated by. They knew only that the man who ruled them had, three days prior, stood before the Universal Committee and asked to be relieved of that rule, and that the war had not ended, and that ending was the only thing they had been promised.

He watched them the way he had once watched the birth of a species, from a great and terrible height, except that the height had worn away over the centuries he had spent among them, and what was left now was closer to level ground. He no longer saw a population. He saw a father who blamed him correctly for a boy who had died following an order that should never have been signed. He saw a woman whose home was rubble because a treaty he had brokered had bought six months of peace and cost her a street. He recognized faces in that crowd the way a man recognizes

debts.

He had not meant for any of it.

Intentions, he had learned, were the cheapest thing a person could own. Everyone had them. Nobody could spend them.

Someone below shouted that without his power, Grin was nothing, and the crowd took the words up as if they had been waiting for someone to say them first, and the sound rolled up toward the window like weather.

He turned from it. In the next room, five children were sleeping, or pretending to.

Act 2: The Cheapest Thing He Owned

To understand why a father was choosing, at that moment, between his children and a mob, it is necessary to go back to before there were mobs, before there was a species capable of forming one, back to a silence so complete it had never needed a name, occupied by a single presence that had also never needed one, because there was nothing yet to distinguish it from.

He had no gender. He had no body. He did not belong to the dimensions in which such things as bodies aged and failed, because those dimensions had not yet been built, and He was the one who would build them.

He made worlds the way other things breathe, continuously, without effort, without much thought given to any single exhale. Among the worlds He made was one called Scapur, and on Scapur He planted a species and gave it reason, curiosity, imagination, and the particular cruelty of being able to choose.

He expected, reasonably enough for a being who had never been wrong before, that a creature capable of understanding consequence would eventually choose to avoid the worst of them. Humanity discovered violence instead. Not by accident, by preference, over and over, generation folding into generation, each one certain it had learned the lesson the last one missed. They fought over land none of them had made. They agreed that certain invisible lines mattered, and then died defending the agreement.

He descended to find out why.

The body He built for the purpose was unremarkable by design, a man's shape, aging convincingly, capable of hunger and boredom and the particular fatigue of standing in long lines that human bureaucracy seemed determined to invent wherever it went. He wore that body through several names before He wore it as Grin. He had the power, at any of those points, to end

every war in a single afternoon.

He never used it.

A peace enforced from above, He reasoned, teaches nothing, it is only a longer leash. If humanity's wars were to end, they had to end because humanity had finally understood something, not because a god had gotten tired of watching. So He guided instead of ruling, or told Himself that was the distinction, and for a long while the distinction held.

Centuries passed the way centuries do for something that does not age, quickly, and then all at once. Humanity crossed the space between stars. It colonized. It specialized, agriculture here, industry there, medicine and trade and, inevitably, war, spread across a hundred systems instead of one. For a time He believed the scale of the thing had finally taught them proportion. It had only taught them appetite.

Colonies became territories. Territories became empires that required, by their nature, something to expand into, and there is always something to expand into if a species is willing to stop asking who already lives there. The Intergalactic War lasted longer than most of the civilizations that started it. Entire planets became evidence.

He negotiated. He built treaties that lasted exactly as long as it took someone powerful to find them inconvenient. He stood, literally, between fleets that wanted each other destroyed, and discovered that a god's body can be shot at like anyone else's, and that being shot at does not stop a war, only delays the shooting.

Then a man risen from nowhere in particular, competent, unremarkable in the ways that mattered least, ruthless in the ways that mattered most, began ending conflicts other leaders had declared permanent. Humanity called him a peacemaker. They did not know they were praising their own maker.

By then He had lived among them so long, in so many failing bodies, that something had happened to Him that He had not designed and could not undo.

He had learned to want something for Himself.

Her name was Hail. She did not know what He was. She did not worship the thing beneath Grin's face, because she never suspected there was a thing beneath it, she loved the face, the voice, the specific and unremarkable ways he took his tea, argued badly, forgot names. He loved her back with an attention he had never once given a galaxy.

They had five children, and each child carried, folded into ordinary human bodies, a fragment of what their father was. The first Ascendants, though no one called them that yet, to Grin they

were simply his, and being simply his was, for a span of years, the most extraordinary thing he had ever made.

He was a father before he was anything else, for exactly as long as Hail was alive to make that possible.

She aged. He did not. She died the way humans die, which is to say completely, and he remained, and so did the five children who would now grow up half-orphaned by a father who could not stop ruling long enough to fully raise them and could not stop grieving long enough to fully rule.

He tried both. He failed at both, more slowly than he expected, which made the failure worse, not better.

Act 3: Five Lights, Two Extinguished

Which returns us to the window, and the crowd, and the five children in the next room who had been listening at the door for longer than he knew.

He had already decided, before the shouting started, that his enemies would not stop at him. A god's children are not an abstraction to men who have just been told their god is stepping down; they are a liability, or a hostage, or a symbol to be broken in public. He had watched enough species turn on their own leadership to know exactly which one this crowd would choose, given time.

So there would be no time.

Five pods were readied before dawn, vessels built for velocities no ordinary body could survive, on the theory, correct as it turned out, that these were not ordinary bodies. As the pods accelerated past what flesh could tolerate, the children's physical forms did not so much die as come apart, releasing what they truly were into a form the pods' own systems had not been built to expect and adapted to anyway, wrapping each child's raw inheritance in a shell of living light. Grin did not watch them launch. He had wanted to. He found, in the end, that some things a father cannot make himself see twice.

The crowd had anticipated the escape. It is a peculiar feature of mobs that they are frequently smarter, collectively, than any single person in them, someone had thought to bring more than torches. Missiles rose to meet two of the five lights before they cleared the atmosphere, and found them.

Two of Grin's children ended there, within sight of the house they had been born in, in the sky above the crowd that had come to remove their father.

A third pod was struck only glancingly, enough to cripple its navigation, not enough to end it. It tumbled off its intended course into a trajectory nobody had planned and nobody could correct, carrying its passenger somewhere that was no longer anywhere in particular.

The remaining two reached their destinations. Where they struck, they struck hard enough to gouge craters into worlds untouched by anything resembling a city, and where the craters should have simply remained scars, they didn't. What poured out of the failing vessels was not blood and was not simply power, it moved through soil and ocean and empty air the way an idea moves through a population that's ready for it, and where it settled, it built.

On one such world, a small, unremarkable stone that would only much later acquire the name Earth, that inheritance became a civilization before it became anything else. The Deities did not evolve there so much as arrive there, fully formed from borrowed divinity, inheriting power without ever meeting the two children whose scattered selves had made them possible. Those two Ascendants slept beneath the world they had accidentally created, their bodies folded into the wreckage of their own pods, and would not wake for longer than any species born of them could conceive of waiting.

The third pod, the crippled one, went on falling through the dark for a span of time that had stopped mattering to the girl asleep inside it. Unlike her brothers, her body had not been destroyed by the launch, only stranded, drifting, preserved by a failing vessel that refused, against every design specification, to let its passenger die.

She had come last, and she would arrive last, and by the time she did, everything that made her arrival strange would already have happened without her.

Act 4: The Last One to Land

Earth had, by then, stopped being merely a Deity homeland. Humanity, the same species that had first learned violence on Scapur, then carried it to a hundred stars, eventually found the planet and decided, in the practical way empires decide things, that a world this far from anywhere useful was better suited to disposal than settlement. Criminals went there. Exiles went there. People a dozen governments had each independently decided they would rather not look at again. They arrived expecting a colony and found a species that did not need their permission to already be thriving.

The Deities could have let them die in that unfamiliar terrain, and for a while, it must be said, several of them argued for exactly that. Instead, enough of them chose otherwise, taught the stranded arrivals which plants killed and which merely made you sick, which caves held water, how to survive weather that owed nothing to any calendar a human had ever built. Fear became

proximity. Proximity became something neither species had a word for yet, until it needed one. The children of those unions were neither fully human nor fully Deity, and they did not all grow the same way. Those raised inside Deity society bent toward what their Deity parent had been, generation deepening into generation, until their descendants had a name of their own: the Enchants. Those raised inside human settlements kept more of their human shape and less of their Deity strength, but the inheritance did not vanish, it thinned, and adapted, and became, eventually, the Evolved.

Two branches. One origin, already forgotten by the time either branch had a name for itself. Beneath all of it, two Ascendants went on sleeping, unaware they had fathered a civilization in their sleep, unaware they had a third sibling still falling toward them across a distance that had, by any human measure, stopped being measurable at all.

She came down at last in a wrecked vessel over a world that had already built two religions out of her brothers without knowing either of their names. Whoever found her found a girl, intact, breathing, entirely unremarkable to look at, and treated her the way one treats a stranger found in wreckage, which is to say with caution, and then with pity, and eventually, once what she could do became impossible to explain any other way, with something closer to worship.

She had not asked for that. She did not know, when it began, that she had two brothers sleeping somewhere beneath the ground she stood on. She did not know two others had already died in the sky above a house she would never see. She did not know her father had once been called Grin, or that Grin had once stood at a window and chosen exile for his children over safety with them, or that the choice had cost him everything it was supposed to save.

She knew only that something inside her was different from everyone around her, and that the difference could be given, the way nothing the Enchants or the Evolved possessed could be given, passed hand to hand, bond to bond, turning ordinary people into something new.

They called her the Creator, because they had no better word, and because the truth, that she was only a fragment of Him, one surviving daughter carrying a splinter of something too large to fit inside any single body, was not a truth anyone standing in front of her had the information to reach.

Somewhere, still, a man who no longer answered to any name walked among a species he had made and had once, briefly, been foolish enough to love without reservation. Somewhere beneath an ordinary-looking world, two of his children dreamed a civilization into being without ever knowing they'd done it. And somewhere in a crowd that had long since dispersed and gone back to blaming other things for its grief, no one remembered that they had once stood outside a window and driven a father into a decision he would spend the rest of unmeasurable time refusing to call a

mistake, because calling it a mistake would have meant admitting there had been a better door to walk through, and there hadn't been. Only worse ones, chosen in the dark, by a man who had run out of better rooms to stand in.

Chapter 2

What the Evolved Could Not Forgive Themselves For

Act 1: The Grief With No Name

A boy named Ostrin could lift a transport crate that took four ordinary men to carry, and for the first nine years of his life, that had been enough.

He used it the way his father had used it, and his father's mother before that, to move stone, to run messages faster than any wheel, to catch a falling roof beam meant for someone else's child. The Evolved of his settlement lived exactly this way: strong enough to matter, never strong enough to rule. They built their cities with their own hands and called the arrangement fair, because for a long time no one had shown them anything to compare it to.

Then a delegation of Enchants passed through, on their way to somewhere more important, and one of them, bored, or careless, or simply young, called down a lightning storm to clear a flooded road in under a minute.

Ostrin watched four years of road work undone and redone in sixty seconds, and something in him that had been sleeping woke up ugly.

It was not envy, exactly. Envy implies wanting what belongs to someone else. What Ostrin felt, and what an entire species of Ostrins would go on feeling for generations, was closer to grief, the grief of discovering that your best had a ceiling, and other people's best did not. The Enchants drew their power from the living world itself, forests, tides, the slow burn of a planet's deep core, and the strength of that bond determined how much they could hold. Given enough connection, they became guardians strong enough to defend the stars they loved, because a dying world made a diminished Enchant, and neither could really be separated from the other. The Divine did not draw from any world at all. They served something above every world, a being their scripture named the Creator, though the name meant less to them as history and more as gravity, an obligation folded into the architecture of what they were. Heavenly Power moved through the willing the way blood moves through a body that has stopped questioning its own pulse. When the demand came, as it eventually came to every Divine Ascendant, to surrender that essence entirely, most gave it without argument. Those who refused were not punished so much as unmade, stripped of the Power that had defined them, cast down to a world built for exactly that purpose, and left there to learn what it felt like to be ordinary again.

Three kinds of power. Three separate answers to the same original question, how does a being reach beyond what it was born as. The Evolved were the only ones who had not yet found their own answer, and eventually the not-having became its own kind of hunger.

Act 2: What Perc Dail Built

The first machines were almost innocent.

Armor, to make an Evolved body harder to break. Focusing rigs, to keep a burst of strength from tearing its own tendons apart. A man named Perc Dail built the first successful set in a barn outside a city that no longer has a name worth keeping, and when he lifted, in that armor, three times what his body alone could bear, the men who watched him wept the way people weep at something they had been told was permanently closed to them.

For a while it was enough to be encouraging.

Then encouraging stopped being enough, the way it always does.

Boosters replaced training. Artificial organs replaced the ones that failed under the new loads. The failures, when they came, came badly, bodies that overheated from the inside, energy that tore through muscle looking for an exit it hadn't been given, Ascendants who absorbed more than their frames could hold and simply stopped, mid-motion, as if a switch somewhere had been thrown. Perc Dail's own daughter died this way, in a lab her father had built, wearing an upgrade her father had approved.

He did not stop the program. He led the search for something better instead, and history has never fully decided whether that makes him a monster or simply a father who could not let his daughter's death be the last word on the subject.

What they found, eventually, was not on any world's surface.

Act 3: The Vein Beneath Merrow

It took eleven years of drilling beneath the crust of a planet called Merrow to reach it, a vein of ore older than the ambitions digging for it, humming faintly enough that the first survey team mistook it for equipment malfunction and nearly abandoned the site. Someone touched it anyway. Hexon, they named it, because names had to come from somewhere and nobody felt like being poetic six kilometers underground.

It did not simply hold energy the way a battery holds energy.

It answered power. It leaned into whatever Ascendant strength came near it and made that strength larger, indiscriminately, with no apparent interest in whether the body wielding it could survive the increase.

The first controlled tests killed everyone in the room. Raw Hexon burned through the men who carried it the way acid burns through paper, not an explosion, something worse, a kind of hunger that ate outward from the point of contact until there was no longer a point, or a contact, or very much left to call a person.

They kept going.

A woman named Sael Ambrus, Perc Dail's second engineer, and by most later accounts the only person on the project who ever fully understood what they were building, found the stabilization method eleven months after the first deaths, in a formula that owed as much to accident as to insight. What emerged from her work was quieter than raw Hexon, contained, almost gentle by comparison. Pure Hexon, they called it, and when an Evolved Ascendant took it into their body for the first time and did not die, and did not scream, and simply stood a little straighter than they had a moment before, the room went silent in a way that had nothing to do with grief.

They had found their answer.

Pure Hexon did not overwrite what an Ascendant already was. It reached toward the bond a person already carried with their source, muscle and instinct for an Evolved, root and current for an Enchant, the old unbroken thread to the Creator for a Divine, and made that bond easier to hold. Power that would once have overwhelmed a body became power that body could simply use. This was called Pure Ascension, and it did not end at a single threshold. The bond, once strengthened, could be strengthened again. And again. Some Ascendants who underwent it climbed a distance from where they started that would have looked, to their own younger selves, like a different species entirely.

Sael Ambrus noted, in a report almost no one read carefully enough at the time, that Pure Hexon did not always require touch. Twice, Pure Ascension had occurred without any Hexon present at all, once during an event that should not have been possible under any law the Ascendants understood, a dead man drawing one final breath four minutes after his heart had stopped for good, long enough to save the child he'd been carrying before he stopped again for the last time. Reality, in these rare cases, seemed to fracture just enough to let something through. They called these fractures Paradoxes, and no one ever succeeded in causing one on purpose, which did not stop several people from trying, sometimes at terrible cost to whoever happened to be standing nearby when a Paradox chose to occur.

Because that was the part the reports underplayed, the part Sael Ambrus herself only admitted late in her life, to a granddaughter who never repeated it publicly: Pure Ascension was never free. Something had to feed the strengthening bond, and if the environment couldn't supply enough on its own, the Ascendant's body reached past itself and took it from whatever was near, a field of crops turned to ash-grey stalks overnight, animals found dead with nothing visibly wrong with them, a village outside one testing ground that woke up one morning simply tired in a way that never fully lifted. Nobody proved a connection. Nobody had to. The people who lived near testing sites knew, the way people always know the thing no one in charge will confirm.

Sometimes the Ascendant's own body could not survive what it demanded of everything around it, and the Ascension took the body too.

That should have been the end of it.

It was not, always.

Act 4: Six Answers, and a Seventh Question

There is a difference, thin as a blade's edge, between an Ascendant whose body fails and an Ascendant whose body is used up entirely. In the second case, on rare and terrible occasions, the life essence still surging through the dying frame found nowhere else to go and forced its way back into the corpse it had just vacated.

The body rose again.

It was not the same body, in any sense that mattered. The bond that Pure Hexon strengthened, this new power corrupted instead, twisting toward pain as its fuel, rage as its accelerant, blood as the closest thing it had to nourishment. A Crimson Ascendant healed wounds that should have ended them by spending the blood already spilled, grew stronger with every act of violence committed, and grew hungrier the stronger they became, in a loop that had no natural floor and, so far as anyone had discovered, no ceiling either.

Crimson Hexon followed not long after, a substance born from the same unstable processes, carrying the same appetite in concentrated form, changing anyone who touched it more fully than it empowered them. There were things called Corruption Parasites, born from Hexon reactions gone wrong in ways too specific to be predicted twice, and these attached to hosts, or consumed them, or in the rarest and worst cases, grew alongside a host until neither one could be called separate from the corruption anymore.

And still separately from all of this, not corrupted, not stolen from the dead, simply unwilling to keep losing organs to a body that failed faster than it could be repaired, the Evolved kept

replacing themselves piece by piece. An arm. A heart. A spine. Eventually entire nervous systems rebuilt in silicon and alloy, minds that could reach into machine networks the way an Enchant reached into soil, consciousness itself backed up somewhere that fire and blood couldn't reach. They called themselves Synthetic Ascendants, and they were, in the end, the most honest of everyone on this list, they had never pretended their strength came from anywhere holy. They had simply refused to accept the strength they were born with, and kept refusing, patiently, one replaced organ at a time, until refusal became its own form of power.

Three kinds, once.

Six, now.

Pure. Divine. Abyss. Enchant. Synthetic. Crimson, each one a different answer to the same original grief a boy named Ostrin had felt watching a storm clear a road that had cost him four years to build by hand.

The Evolved had wanted, more than anything else, to stop being the weakest voice in a conversation that never once asked their opinion. In trying, they had built miracles. They had also built monsters, and had rarely managed to keep the two apart for very long, and history, which is patient about these things in a way people rarely are, has still not finished deciding which of those outcomes it will remember first.

Somewhere among all of it, in records too scattered to have been gathered by any single mind yet, one question kept resurfacing in the margins of reports nobody in power wanted to prioritize. Six paths had already been found by beings who refused to stay what they were born.

Nothing in any of those records explained why the number should stop there.

Chapter 3

The Second Time the Sky Opened

Act 1: The Fall of Corvessa Thane

A woman named Corvessa Thane spent the last conscious minute of her old life watching a planet she had never seen before rush up to meet her, and thinking, with the strange calm that sometimes arrives exactly when calm is least useful, that at least the fall was pretty. She had been a magistrate's clerk. Before that, unimportant. The pod had no window worth the name, only a scarred porthole the size of a hand, but it was enough to show her green where she had expected only rock, and blue where the manifest had promised nothing but a penal outpost too far from anywhere to matter.

She did not know the planet already had a name among the people who lived on it. She did not know it had three names, in three different mouths, none of which agreed. She struck the ground still not knowing any of that, and woke two days later in a room built by hands twice the length of her own, tended by a face that was almost human and was not, and the first thought she managed to form clearly was that whatever this was, it had chosen, for reasons she could not begin to guess, to save her instead of letting her die.

She would spend the rest of her life trying to earn that choice back. Her grandchildren would spend theirs forgetting it had ever needed earning.

Act 2: Two Vessels, One Silence

To understand why that face bent over her without hesitation, it is necessary to go back much further than any prison ship, back to a night, if nights meant anything yet, when two vessels the length of small moons struck a planet hard enough to remake it.

The Ascendants inside those vessels did not die on impact. Their bodies remained where the wreckage held them, but what they were stopped, gradually and then entirely, being separable from the world around them. Their power moved into stone, into water, into the marrow of every living thing that would ever grow there, and settled, and slept, and kept working long after the sleeping began.

From that unconscious labor came the Deities, tall, unhurried, built to a scale that made the world's later inhabitants look, by comparison, like something added as an afterthought. They did not know what had made them. The two sleeping shapes beneath the ground became, over the

ages, first a memory, then a mystery, then simply a story told to children about why the earth in certain places still felt warm to a bare foot at midnight.

The Deities built cities meant to outlast weather. Some of what they raised is still standing, mistaken by later eyes for the work of a much smaller and much more recent species. They lived, for a very long stretch of their history, without needing to share the planet with anyone. Then the first humans arrived, not conquerors, not even settlers by choice. Cargo. A civilization far away had decided this world was distant enough to be useful only as a place to put people it no longer wanted, and so it sent them, the same way it would go on sending them for millennia afterward, without much curiosity about what they'd find when they landed.

What they found terrified them. What found them chose, for reasons the Deities themselves might not have fully agreed on among each other, to help rather than to hunt.

It is worth pausing on that choice, because everything that came after depended on it, and because it was not unanimous. Among the Deities who gathered around that first stranded settlement, there was an elder, her name has not survived, though her decision has, who argued that creatures so easily broken by their own new home would only ever be a danger to it eventually, and that the mercy about to be extended would not be remembered as mercy for very long.

She was outvoted. She was, in the way of these things, also correct, though it would take her people several hundred years to find that out.

Act 3: Cargo From Another Sky

Kindness, given time, becomes proximity. Proximity, given more time, becomes something neither side had a word ready for. Deities and humans built lives beside each other, and some of those lives became one life, and the children of those unions looked human enough to walk unremarked through either world, while carrying, folded somewhere beneath the skin, an inheritance neither world could fully claim.

The Hybrids did not all grow up the same. Those raised inside Deity settlements bent, generation over generation, toward what their Deity parent had been, until their descendants stopped being called Hybrids at all, and became instead a people of their own: the Enchants, bonded to the living current of the world the way their ancestors had been born already bonded to it. Those raised inside human settlements kept more of their human shape and less of their Deity strength, and their descendants, generation over generation, became the Evolved, stronger than ordinary humans, sharper, harder to kill, but never quite believing, not even among themselves, that the difference made them something other than human.

Two branches from one root. Neither more legitimate than the other. Both, for a while, at peace with what they were.

The peace did not survive contact with fear.

Act 4: Two Branches From One Root

It began the way these things generally do, small, deniable, and completely irreversible. A human settlement, remembering enough of the civilizations it had come from to distrust anything larger and stranger than itself, attacked a Deity town near its border. The Deities defended themselves and won every engagement individually and lost the war anyway, because humans, whatever they lacked in strength, arrived in numbers no single defense could outlast. What followed did not stay contained to one settlement, or one grievance, or even one generation. Deity cities emptied into forests and underground shelters. Hybrids were forced to choose a side neither side fully trusted them to be loyal to, and chose, in the end, every possible way a person can choose, some for the Deities who had raised them, some for the humans who shared their blood, some simply for whichever side offered to leave their own children alone. Then the war stopped being local at all. The greater Intergalactic War, already grinding through a hundred other systems, finally reached the planet that had been trying, badly, to have its own smaller war in private. Whatever arrived from beyond Earth's sky did not distinguish between the combatants already fighting there. Human settlements burned beside Deity cities. Evolved communities vanished beside Enchant ones. When it finally stopped, not because anyone had won, but because there was, at last, almost no one left with the numbers to keep fighting, four peoples stood in the wreckage of what had once been four separate claims to the same world, and none of them had enough left to make a fifth claim worth pursuing.

Peace arrived the way it does after exhaustion rather than forgiveness. It is a colder kind of peace, and it lasts exactly as long as no one is forced to remember what caused the war in the first place.

For a long while, no one was.

The Deities rebuilt in what territory remained theirs. The Enchants gathered into small communities near the surviving Deities, close enough to keep the old alliance breathing, distant enough from the human remnants to keep the old wound from reopening by accident. The Evolved rebuilt alongside what was left of humanity, because that had always been the branch closer to human shape and human memory, and it stayed that way now by simple proximity.

Generations passed. The war became history. History, patiently, became folklore, and folklore does not insist on accuracy, it only insists on being retold. Deities and Enchants kept the truth

close, inherited directly from grandparents who had lived it. The Evolved, embedded more deeply in human settlements than in their own separate memory, inherited a softer, more forgivable version, in which the fault sat more evenly, or not at all, on anyone still living.

Then the sky opened again, and a magistrate's clerk named Corvessa Thane fell out of it, knowing none of this, into a world that remembered everything she didn't.

Act 5: A War With No Winners

The three surviving peoples had every reason, this second time, to let the newcomers die the way the first Deity elder had once predicted they eventually would.

They did not.

The Deities offered food and shelter to strangers who could not have named a single Deity city if their lives depended on it, which, in the earliest weeks, they very often did. The Enchants healed injuries the newcomers didn't understand had been healed, using methods the newcomers assumed were simply medicine. The Evolved, closest in shape, closest in memory, closest in blood to the people falling out of the sky, taught them how to eat, build, and survive a world that still killed the unprepared efficiently and without malice.

The newcomers never learned there were three separate peoples helping them. The Deities were unmistakably other, too large and too strange to be mistaken for anything human. But the Evolved and the Enchants looked, to eyes that had no reason yet to look closer, exactly like people, a little stronger here, a little stranger there, put down to family trait rather than to four separate branches of one very old event. The Evolved, for their part, rarely corrected the assumption. Neither did the Enchants, at first, though for entirely different reasons, the Evolved because the mistake cost them nothing and bought them belonging, the Enchants because the truth had never once, in their people's memory, bought anyone anything but grief.

Corvessa Thane spent forty years believing the woman who'd nursed her back from the crash was simply a neighbor with an unusual gift, and died without ever learning otherwise, and was, in this, entirely representative of her generation.

Act 6: The Second Kindness

It could have stayed that way. For a while, remarkably, it did, an unlikely, unearned stretch of decades in which four peoples who each remembered a different amount of the same war lived close enough to trade, to marry, to raise children who knew nothing of any of it.

But settlements grow the way settlements always grow, which is to say past whatever border first contained them, and memory fades the way memory always fades in the people who were never taught to carry it, faster in the ones who have the luxury of forgetting, slower in the ones who do not.

The Enchants remembered. That was the trouble, in the end, not villainy on any side, not a single clean cause a historian could point to and call the reason, only the oldest and least original problem there is: some of the people living beside each other could forget the last war, and some of them could not, and no war has ever been settled purely by asking the second group to try harder.

An Enchant elder named Ysbel Corr, one of the very last living people who had heard the old war described by someone who had actually fought in it, stood before her own community's council when the first serious border dispute reached them, and said only this: "They do not know what their grandfathers did to ours."

A younger voice from the same council answered her: "Then tell them."

Ysbel did not answer that directly. She looked instead at the border map spread across the table between them, at the human settlement markers creeping, year over year, closer to lines that had once meant something and now meant nothing to anyone who hadn't drawn them.

"Telling them," she said eventually, "has never once stopped anyone from taking what they already believed was theirs to take."

It was not agreement. It was not refusal either. It was the answer of a woman who had watched one war begin from exactly this kind of small, reasonable-sounding dispute, and did not believe explaining the last one would prevent the next.

She was right not to believe it.

Act 7: The Seam That Never Healed

The dispute that finally broke the peace has been remembered at least four different ways by the four peoples who were there for it, and no version fully agrees with any other. Humans say the Enchants struck first, over territory that had never been properly settled between them. Enchants say the humans had been warned, repeatedly, and chose expansion over caution anyway. The Evolved, caught geographically and by blood between both accounts, tend to say only that it was fear, on every side, wearing whatever justification came to hand first.

What is agreed on is smaller and colder than any of the explanations: a human settlement moved against a small Enchant community near a border that had held, without incident, for three

generations. The Enchants fought back with everything the old bond to the living world could give them. The humans answered with everything their numbers could give them. The Deities, watching a shape they recognized far too well beginning to repeat itself, moved to intervene, and the Evolved, closer to humanity in blood, closer to the Enchants in memory, belonging fully to neither side of the argument, found themselves forced, again, to choose.

This time, the humans doing the choosing did not even know what they were choosing between. They did not know the people they were fighting had once saved their grandparents' lives without asking for gratitude. They did not know the Evolved standing among them shared the same distant blood as the Enchants they were sending soldiers against. They did not know the Deities had extended mercy to their species twice now, unearned both times, and were watching a third betrayal assemble itself out of the same tired ingredients as the first.

They knew only that something in this world was resisting them, and that resistance, to a species with no memory of ever having been the fragile ones, looked exactly like provocation. The old peace, cold, unforgiven, but real, did not survive the season.

Somewhere beneath all of it, two children of a being none of the four peoples remembered correctly went on sleeping, still unaware that the civilization built from their scattered power was, for the second time in its short remembered history, about to tear itself open along the same old seam.

And somewhere else on the same planet, closer to the surface than either sleeping sibling, a third child of that same being, arrived far later, mistaken by everyone who met her for something she was only a fragment of, had not yet learned that the war beginning around her had already happened once before, to people who no longer had any living memory of how it had ended, only of the fact that it had.

Chapter 4

The Girl Who Learned What Worship Was For

Act 1: The Third Man on the Altar

The third man to attempt the ritual convulsed for eleven seconds and then simply stopped, the way a lamp stops when the oil runs out, not dramatically, just an absence where a moment ago there had been a flame.

His name was Torvin Ashe, and he had spent four years believing himself devoted enough to survive what the first two men hadn't. He had fasted. He had given away land. He had knelt in temples built in a woman's honor long after his knees had stopped forgiving him for it. When his body finally failed on the altar stone, the priests around him did not weep so much as make notes, because grief, at this stage of the enterprise, had already been budgeted for.

Mei watched from across the chamber, arms folded, and said nothing for a long moment. Then she said, "Try the next one differently. He held his breath through all of it. Tell him not to."

It was not cruelty. It rarely was, with her. It was closer to the tone of a craftsman troubleshooting a tool that kept breaking in the same predictable place, and if that tone unsettled the priests more than open malice would have, none of them ever said so to her directly. To understand how a girl becomes someone capable of watching a man die on an altar built for her and immediately begin solving the problem, it helps to go back to the forest where she was found, small and unafraid, in wreckage that should have killed anything human.

Act 2: The Child Who Wasn't Afraid

The Enchants who found the crater expected humans. They had found humans before, fallen from the sky in cruder vessels, frightened and half-starved and grateful. What they found instead was a child sitting upright in the ruin of her pod, entirely unhurt, looking back at them with the mild curiosity of someone waiting to be told what happened next.

The oldest among them felt it before the youngest did, a wrongness in her that had nothing to do with malice and everything to do with scale. Ordinary magic, the kind that moved through an Enchant's blood after generations of inherited bond, had a texture the oldest could recognize with their eyes closed. What moved through this child had no texture at all. It simply was her, the way water is wet, with no separation between the girl and the force running through her.

They debated what to do with her the way frightened people debate anything, badly, and at length, and never quite reaching consensus. Some wanted to study her. Some wanted her destroyed before whatever slept inside her woke fully. In the end they did neither, because doing either required someone to walk toward her first, and for three full days, nobody did. She solved that problem herself, eventually, by walking into their camp uninvited and asking, without any apparent awareness that the question might unsettle anyone further, why everyone kept hiding from her when she could see exactly where they were standing.

An elder answered, from a safe distance, that she was not what she appeared to be.

"I know," the girl said. "I don't know what I am either. Is that supposed to be frightening?" Nobody answered her. She shrugged, the particular shrug of a child who has decided the adults in the room are being unreasonable and doesn't intend to waste more energy on the argument, and went looking for somewhere else to be a person.

They named her Mei before they worked up the nerve to ask her whether she already had a name. She did not correct them. It is possible she didn't have one to offer.

Act 3: A Girl Who Liked Being Useful

She left the Enchants within a year, drawn, by instinct or boredom, the record does not distinguish, toward the human settlements where the Evolved lived closest to ordinary people. Humans did not carry the old instinct the Enchants had for recognizing wrongness in a bloodline; to them, Mei was simply a remarkable child, the kind every generation produces one or two of, until the things she did stopped fitting inside that explanation.

She lifted what should have required ten Evolved men and did not appear to notice the effort. She stopped a wall from finishing its collapse onto a group of children with one raised hand and looked mildly surprised that anyone found this remarkable. She did not hide any of it, because it never occurred to her that hiding was a thing people in her position generally chose to do. Word travels faster than caution. An Evolved soldier who had watched her hold up a falling roof told three others. A woman whose dying orchard she'd restored in an afternoon told her whole village. A child who'd watched her call rain down over cracked, drought-starved fields told anyone who would listen, for the rest of a very long life, and was believed less each time she told it, right up until the year everyone finally understood she'd been telling the truth all along. They started asking her for things. She gave them, because giving cost her nothing she could measure and made people around her happier than she'd previously understood people were capable of being. For a while, that was the whole of it, a girl who liked being useful, mistaking usefulness for the entire shape of what she was.

Act 4: The Answer That Came From Belief

She noticed the pattern the way most discoveries happen, sideways, while looking for something else entirely.

A village had begun gathering at dusk to give thanks for a harvest she'd saved, and during one such gathering, kneeling and murmuring and genuinely believing, for reasons she hadn't asked them to supply, that she could hear them and would keep them safe if they only trusted her enough, she felt something answer that had nothing to do with the wheat she'd grown or the rain she'd called. It moved toward her the way heat moves toward an open door, and it did not come from the ground, or from any living thing nearby.

She tested it, carefully, the way she tested everything, by asking for more of the same and seeing whether more of the same arrived. She asked a second village to build her a shrine. She asked a third to gather and simply believe, out loud, together, that she was capable of everything they hoped she was. Each time, the answering force grew a little stronger, a little easier to feel, until she stopped needing to ask for it consciously and started simply noticing it arrive whenever enough people, in enough rooms, decided together that she was worth trusting entirely. She understood, before she had a name for it, that this was not magic in any sense the Enchants would have recognized, and not strength in any sense the Evolved possessed. It came from somewhere she had never seen and could not point to, and it grew in direct proportion to how completely other people surrendered their fear to her.

They had already given her a name for what she was, long before she found the right one for the power itself. They called her their God.

She let them.

Not, in fairness to her, out of vanity, she never once claimed to be flawless, and would have been genuinely confused by anyone who accused her of pretending otherwise. She let them because the name was, as far as she could tell, simply accurate to what was happening, and Mei had never been a person who saw much use in refusing an accurate description of herself.

Act 5: What Sarei Voss Became

What she wanted, once she understood the shape of the power, was more of it, and the fastest way to get more of anything, she'd already learned from watching farmers manage crops, was to plant more of whatever produced it.

She could not hand her own power to another person directly, she tried, in the earliest attempts, and the results convinced her quickly that whatever this force was, it required a soul to

reach for it on its own rather than simply receive it as a gift. So she built rituals instead. She taught devotion as a discipline, the way an instructor teaches a sword stance, refining it each time a student failed, treating each failure as data rather than as tragedy, which was either the most honest way to survive what she was doing or the first sign of something in her that had already stopped being entirely a girl.

Torvin Ashe was neither the first nor the last to die on her altar stone. He was, however, adjacent to the first true success, a woman named Sarei Voss, who followed him onto the same stone four days later, having been told, on Mei's specific instruction, to breathe through the pain rather than hold against it.

Sarei did not die. She screamed for eleven minutes, which those present later swore felt considerably longer, and when it ended, something in her had changed at a level deeper than skin. She stood on legs that no longer belonged entirely to a human body, looked at her own hands as if they'd been swapped out overnight for someone else's, and asked, in a voice still raw from screaming, what she was now.

"Divine," Mei told her, and the word had never existed with that meaning before the moment she said it.

Act 6: A Bridge With No Far Side

The system that grew from Sarei Voss's survival did not require cruelty to sustain itself, which made it, in the long run, considerably more dangerous than if it had. Every Divine Ascendant who survived the ritual became not merely a follower but a second thread reaching toward whatever lay beyond Earth, and every thread widened the channel a little further, and the widened channel made the next Ascension a little more survivable, which meant more attempts, which meant more threads.

Temples rose in places that had never needed temples before. Kings who had spent their reigns fighting each other over grain and borders sent envoys asking for her blessing instead, having quietly concluded that her favor was worth more than the grain. Evolved warriors who had spent their lives being told they were the strongest thing a human body could become knelt in her name and discovered they meant it. Even a handful of Enchants, the ones young enough not to remember the fear their elders had felt in that first forest, or old enough to have finally decided fear had cost their people more than curiosity ever would, began, quietly, to allow that she might be something worth aligning with rather than something to be watched from a safe distance. Not everyone kneeled. There were always some, among Enchants especially, whose collective memory ran longer and colder than anyone else's, who watched the temples multiply and the kings bow and said, to whoever would listen, that no single being should be allowed to become this

necessary to this many people at once. They were rarely wrong. They were also, by then, rarely in a position to be listened to.

Mei herself changed slower than her religion did, which is perhaps the most honest thing that can be said of her. She still remembered being a child who had simply wanted people to stop being afraid of her. She still, on nights when the temples were quiet and the priests had gone to sleep, wondered, in a way she never let her Divine Ascendants see, where exactly she had come from, and whether the power moving through her belonged to her at all, or was only borrowed from something enormous and distant that had never once, in all the years since her pod struck the ground, bothered to explain itself.

She had a name for whatever that distant thing was, though she had chosen it herself, without proof, the same practical way she chose everything: the Creator. She did not know if the name was accurate. She did not know if the being it described was watching her build an empire out of borrowed devotion, or had never noticed her at all, or was even still capable of noticing anything, wherever it was.

She only knew that the temples kept multiplying, and the power kept answering, and somewhere above all of it, beyond the sky her pod had fallen through, beyond the reach of every Divine Ascendant she had ever made, there was a source she had still never once managed to touch directly.

So she kept building the only bridge she knew how to build, one convert, one shrine, one ritual at a time, reaching upward with both hands toward something that had never yet reached back.

Chapter 5

The Story He Did Not Know Was His

Act 1: The Fool King's Story

In a town whose name would not survive the century, a man with a worn instrument on his back told a story about a king who had given up his throne and lost his children to the sky. He told it the way he told everything, lightly, for coin and applause, embroidering the sad parts until they were easier to laugh at than to feel. In his version, the king was a fool who mistook mercy for weakness. The crowd loved that king. Fools who lose everything make for better company than kings who lose everything for a reason, and the man had learned, over more years than he could number, which version an audience would pay for.

"And so," he said, raising his cup toward the low tavern rafters, "the fool sent his own children into the sky rather than admit he couldn't protect them on the ground. Two burned before they cleared the roof. One vanished. Two more built whole worlds without him and never learned his name."

The tavern laughed at the right places. Someone near the fire called out to ask whether the fool ever found the missing one.

"No one knows," the man said, and meant it more literally than his audience understood. "That's why it's a good story. Good stories don't finish. They just stop being told for a while." He drank. The room moved on to wanting a different tale, one with a monster in it, and he gave them that instead, and somewhere behind his eyes, for the length of perhaps two heartbeats, something had tried very hard to surface and failed.

He did not notice the failure. He had stopped noticing most of them by then.

Act 2: The Hands That Reached In Too Far

He had not always told stories for a living. There had been a time, long enough ago that even his memory of having forgotten it had mostly worn smooth, when he had believed knowing what would happen gave him the right to change it.

He had warned kings away from wars they were fated to lose, and watched some of them lose anyway, on schedule, as if his warning had only rearranged which soldiers died and not whether they would. He had loved a woman once, fully, the way only something that had never needed to love before is capable of loving the first time it tries, and time had taken her from him regardless

of what he knew or didn't know about the shape of the future. He had built things meant to outlast grief and discovered that grief outlasts almost everything.

After that, he stopped intervening.

It was not surrender, exactly, though it looked enough like surrender that he stopped correcting people who called it that. It was closer to the decision a man makes after enough failed surgeries, that his hands, however capable, had done more damage reaching in than they had done good. So when he saw a king marching toward a battle that would end him, he no longer warned the king. He told a story about a king who marched toward a battle that ended him, and let the actual king overhear it if fate arranged the seating that way, and did not follow up to see whether the overhearing had changed anything.

When he saw a woman falling in love with a man who would eventually ruin her, he did not step between them. He told a story about a woman and a man like that, in a town two rivers away, where no one present had any stake in the outcome, and moved on before the story could grow roots.

It was easier that way. Easier for him, at least. Whether it was easier for the people whose futures he declined to touch was a question he had stopped being equipped to answer honestly, because by then he could no longer always tell, from the inside, which of his stories were warnings and which were simply stories.

Act 3: What He Burned Rather Than Read

Centuries do not pass evenly for a man who does not age through them. They accumulate instead, the way silt accumulates at a river's mouth, indistinguishable grain from indistinguishable grain, until one day the man realizes the riverbed itself has moved and he can no longer say when. He watched kingdoms fold into ruin and ruin fold into hillside and hillside erode into something no one would ever again recognize as having once held a throne room. He watched oceans migrate. He watched a desert bloom into forest and, several lifetimes later, watched the same forest burn back down into the same desert, as if the land itself had only been trying out two possible futures and hadn't yet decided which one it preferred.

His memory did not keep pace with any of it. Faces went first, he would meet a woman and feel certain, with no evidence to support the certainty, that he had loved someone with her exact laugh several ages ago, and never be able to recall whether that was true or simply the shape loneliness takes after enough centuries of it. Names went next, then the places those names had belonged to, then, this was the loss that frightened him most, in the years he could still be frightened by anything, the specific reasons he had once had for setting out on any of this in the

first place.

He tried, for a while, to hold the losses off with method. He kept notebooks of names. He drew maps of worlds he was afraid he'd stop being able to place. He wrote, longhand, across seasons, an account of his own life, meaning to anchor himself to it the way a ship anchors to a seabed it can no longer see.

He finished the account on a winter evening in a room he would not remember three years later, and made the mistake of reading the first page back to himself.

He did not recognize the man it described.

He burned it before he could decide whether that was mercy or cowardice, and afterward found that he felt something close to relief, which frightened him more than the burning had. From then on, he stopped trying to hold on to himself. He turned his attention outward instead, toward everyone else's stories, because those, unlike his own, did not require him to remember anything he had lost the right to claim.

Act 4: Every Version That Was True

There were more stories than any single mind should have been able to hold, and he held them anyway, because holding them had become the only shape his existence still had.

He watched a woman die in one place while, in some other place he could not have named the distance to, a child took her first breath at the exact same hour, as if the universe had simply moved one soul's ledger entry to a different column rather than closing the account. He watched a city fall to fire while, elsewhere, an identical city's foundations were being laid by masons who would never know their work echoed a ruin they'd never see. He watched a man face a choice and, in some fold of existence he had no ordinary way of reaching, and no ordinary way of explaining afterward, watched the same man, wearing a different fate, choose differently.

He came, slowly and without any single moment he could point to as the turn, to understand something that should have terrified him and instead simply exhausted him into a kind of peace: time was not a road he was walking along. It was not behind him, or ahead of him. It did not have a direction that applied to what he had become.

Every story he told was true somewhere, because somewhere was no longer a place with borders. A king who had never existed in the town he was drinking in had absolutely existed in some other fold of what could be. A war he invented on the spot to entertain a room full of strangers had been fought, in full, complete with its grief and its survivors, in some other accounting of events he would never personally visit. He was not lying when he told his stories.

He had simply stopped being able to promise which version of true he was describing on any given night.

That was the part no listener ever understood, and the part he stopped trying to explain to them. To the people drinking in front of him, a story was a thing that had happened, once, in a place with a name, or else it hadn't happened at all and calling it true was simply a kindness extended to a good performance. To him, by then, a story was closer to a room in a house too large to ever finish walking through, real the moment you stood in it, real for as long as anyone stood there with you, and no less real for the fact that most people would only ever see one room and assume the house ended at its walls.

Act 5: A Name He Never Chose

Different places gave him different names, over the ages, none of which he corrected and none of which he claimed. The Dreamer. The Wonderer. The Man Without a Name, which came closest to accurate and pleased him least, because it implied a name had once existed to be without. He answered to whichever one a given fire's worth of strangers offered him, the way a man answers to whatever a river happens to be called on either side of a border he's forgotten the name of himself.

One name outlasted the others, though he could never afterward say which town, or which century, had first offered it to him. It began, as far as anyone could reconstruct, as a joke, a farmer, annoyed at being outwitted in an argument about whether a story he'd just been told could possibly be true, throwing up his hands and declaring that arguing with the man was pointless, since apparently he already knew everything worth knowing, better than anyone else could hope to. The name stuck the way jokes sometimes do, long after the joke itself has been forgotten by everyone who first laughed at it.

He did not choose it. He simply stopped correcting it, the way he had stopped correcting all the others, and somewhere in the slow accumulation of centuries during which he answered to it without ever quite deciding to, it became less a name given to him and more a description of what was left once nearly everything else about him had worn away.

Not because he remembered everything.

Because he had forgotten enough of himself that there was finally room for everything else.

Act 6: The Fire Still Waiting

He no longer traveled toward anywhere. He traveled because a fire was always burning somewhere ahead of him, and a fire meant people, and people meant a story waiting to be asked for.

On the night this account finds him last, he sat at the edge of one such fire, his instrument silent across his back, listening to a child ask whether the tale he'd told an hour earlier, about a fool king who had sent his own children into the sky rather than watch strangers take them, had really happened, or whether he had made it up the way grown-ups made up most things when they wanted a child to fall asleep faster.

He looked at the child for a moment longer than the question required.

"Somewhere," he said, "it happened exactly the way I told it. Somewhere else, it happened a little differently. And somewhere, probably, it's still happening right now, to a king who hasn't lost his children yet and doesn't know tonight is the night he will."

The child considered this with the total seriousness only children and the very old are capable of, and asked which version was the true one.

He did not answer immediately. Whatever had almost surfaced in that first tavern, in that first telling of the same story, stirred again, closer to the surface than it had come in longer than he could measure, a window. A crowd he couldn't quite picture. A weight in his chest shaped exactly like five names he could no longer read even though some part of him was certain, in that instant, that he had once known every one of them by heart.

It passed, the way it always passed.

"All of them," he told the child instead, and meant it, because by then it was the only honest answer left available to him. "That's what makes it worth telling twice."

He added a log to the fire. Somewhere beyond the reach of that light, beyond the fire, beyond the town, beyond the particular fold of existence in which an old man with no name he could fully claim sat telling stories to a child who would grow old and forget most of them, the story continued anyway, in every place it had ever been or would ever be true, waiting, patiently, the way it always had, for someone to sit down and tell it again.